

Japan Travel Guide

20 days · September · For families with young kids

NORTH OF TOKYO

Nikko & Nasu

Ancient cedar forests, UNESCO shrines dripping in gold leaf, sacred waterfalls — and some of Japan's most dramatic mountain onsen. An easy day trip from Tokyo that rewards an overnight stay.

Nikko

- Toshogu Shrine complex — one of Japan's most ornate (the "see no evil" monkeys are here)
- Kegon Falls — 97m waterfall, best from the elevator observation deck
- Lake Chuzenji — rent a boat or just stare at the water
- [Official Nikko tourism site](#)

Kinugawa Onsen

Just 30 minutes from Nikko by train — a classic Japanese hot spring resort town hugging a dramatic gorge. The river runs a vivid green-blue between steep forested cliffs, and the onsen ryokan line both banks. A great pairing: culture in Nikko, relaxation in Kinugawa. Kids love the river boat rides and the slightly retro theme park energy of the town.

- Kinugawa gorge boat ride (Kinugawa Raft) — float down the rapids between towering canyon walls
- Edo Wonderland (Nikko Edomura) — a full-scale recreation of an Edo-period town with ninja shows, samurai, and geisha performances. One of the best theme parks of its kind in Japan.
- Ryuokyo Gorge — a short walk along the cliff-side trail above the emerald river, one of Tochigi's most scenic spots
- Onsen ryokan — stay at least one night; the classic riverside inns with open-air baths overlooking the gorge are the whole point
- [Kinugawa Onsen tourism](#)
- [Edo Wonderland](#)

The Ritz-Carlton Nikko

Right on Lake Chuzenji. Floor-to-ceiling lake views, exceptional onsen, flawless service. Worth the splurge for at least one night — the breakfast with the lake mist in the morning is unforgettable.

- [Ritz-Carlton Nikko](#)

Nasu Highlands

- Safari Park — drive-through wildlife with lions and bears
- Nasu Animal Kingdom — farm animals and hands-on experiences, perfect for 5-year-olds
- Hot spring town Nasu Yumoto — very relaxed, family-friendly

- [Nasu tourism info](#)
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TOHOKU — DEEPER NORTH

Aomori & Lake Towada

Raw, unhurried, and still off the radar for most international visitors. Tohoku rewards those who make the journey north.

Hoshino Risonare Aomoriya

A resort built around Aomori's festival culture — Nebuta lantern floats, tsugaru shamisen performances, outdoor hot springs under the stars. Part luxury resort, part living museum of Tohoku. The kids' activities here are excellent.

- [Risonare Aomoriya official site](#)

Lake Towada & Oirase Gorge

A caldera lake so clear it doesn't look real. The Oirase Gorge trail follows a crystal river through ancient moss-carpeted forest — one of Japan's most beautiful walks, especially as September brings early autumn colour to the trees.

- [Towada-Hachimantai NP info](#)
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HOKKAIDO

Asahikawa → Furano → Biei → Higashikawa

Japan's northern island is a completely different country — wide open skies, dairy farms, lavender fields, and no crowds. September is ideal: summer flowers are fading but the autumn foliage hasn't started yet, so prices are lower.

Furano & Biei

- Furano lavender (Farm Tomita) — blooms July-Aug but the rolling landscape is stunning year-round
- Biei patchwork hills — rent a bike or drive the Panorama Road slowly
- Shirogane Blue Pond — an otherworldly blue-white pool near Biei, one of Japan's most surreal natural sights
- [Farm Tomita \(lavender\)](#)
- [Biei tourism](#)

Higashikawa — Japan's photography town

Officially designated as Japan's photography town (写真の町), Higashikawa has built an entire identity around the art of photography — hosting a major international photo festival every summer, maintaining public galleries, and attracting artists from across Japan. But the story goes deeper: over the past decade, Higashikawa has become one of Japan's most remarkable migration success stories. Young families, artisans, and creatives have been relocating here in striking numbers — completely bucking Japan's rural depopulation trend — drawn by the quality of life, an international school, and a municipal government that actively courts new residents.

Artisan furniture makers, natural spring water flowing from every tap (straight from the mountains, no treatment), craft sake breweries, and a general sense that interesting people have chosen to be here. It doesn't feel like a tourist destination. It feels like somewhere people actually want to live.

- [Higashikawa town site](#)
- [Higashikawa Photo Festival](#)

Asahikawa

Hokkaido's second city is more than just a gateway — it has real character, excellent ramen, and two of Hokkaido's best attractions within easy reach.

- Asahiyama Zoo — Japan's most creative zoo, famous for polar bears swimming overhead through a glass tunnel, penguins waddling along a snow parade route, and enclosures designed to show animals behaving naturally rather than pacing in cages
- Asahikawa Ramen — one of Japan's four great ramen styles, characterised by rich soy-based broth with a layer of lard on top to keep it hot in the brutal Hokkaido winters. Eat at Aoba or Hachiya, both legendary.
- Ueno Farm — a stunning English-style garden designed by landscape architect Noriko Ueno, at its peak in late August through September
- Otokoyama Sake Brewery Museum — free entry, tastings of one of Hokkaido's most respected sake labels, with a view over the Taisetsu mountain range
- [Asahiyama Zoo](#)
- [Ueno Farm](#)

WEST OF TOKYO — MOUNTAINS

Yatsugatake & Hokuto, Yamanashi

The Yatsugatake mountain range sits on the border of Yamanashi and Nagano, and the area around Hokuto City (北杜市) is one of Japan's best-kept secrets for those who know it. My wife's family has a villa here, and we visit regularly — so this is a genuine insider recommendation, not just a travel brochure pick.

The area

Hokuto is consistently ranked among Japan's most liveable rural municipalities — clean mountain air, some of the highest sunshine hours in Japan, pristine water from the Southern Alps, and a farming culture that produces outstanding vegetables, wine, and whisky (Suntory's Hakushu distillery is here). The pace is completely different from Tokyo. September is ideal — the summer heat has broken, the harvest is in, and the mountains turn gold at the edges.

- Horseback riding — the Yatsugatake area is one of Japan's most established equestrian regions, with multiple riding clubs offering trail rides through forest and farmland
- Outdoor activities — climbing, mountain biking, zip lines, forest walks, adventure parks. The terrain makes it one of the best places in the Kanto/Chubu region for active families.
- Suntory Hakushu Distillery — one of Japan's great whisky distilleries, set in a forest at the foot of the mountains. Tours available, with tasting.
- Shishi-iwa House — an architecturally remarkable boutique hotel by Kengo Kuma, for a special night
- [Hokuto City tourism](#)

- [Suntory Hakushu Distillery](#)

Risonare Yatsugatake

The area's flagship resort, and the natural anchor for a stay here. Stargazing observatory (the mountain altitude and low light pollution make it exceptional), horseback riding on site, rock climbing walls, farm-to-table dining sourced from local Hokuto producers, and a cobblestone Italian-village street that is inexplicably charming. This is the resort that converts kids who think nature is boring.

- [Risonare Yatsugatake official site](#)

WEST OF TOKYO — RESORT TOWN

Karuizawa

Karuizawa is arguably Japan's most internationally recognised resort destination — and for good reason. Sitting at 1,000m altitude in the Nagano mountains, it was discovered by foreign missionaries in the late 19th century as an escape from Tokyo's summer heat, and that international character has never left. Today it draws a uniquely cosmopolitan crowd: Tokyo's creative and business elite, international residents, and a growing number of overseas tourists who have heard about it through design and travel media. It's one of the few places in Japan where you regularly hear English, French, and Mandarin on the street without being in a major city.

Why so many international visitors

- Climate — at 1,000m, summer temperatures are 5-8°C cooler than Tokyo. September is particularly beautiful: clear skies, golden light, and the first hints of autumn colour.
- Architecture and design — Karuizawa has a long tradition of interesting buildings, from old missionary summer houses to contemporary architecture. The density of good design per square kilometre is unusual for Japan outside of major cities.
- Food and shopping — the Harunire Terrace in particular has become a design-forward dining and retail destination that rivals anything in Tokyo
- Nature access — Shiraito Falls, hiking in the Asama foothills, cycling paths through the birch forest — all within 20 minutes of the station
- Easy access — 1 hour 10 minutes from Tokyo on the Hokuriku Shinkansen. One of Japan's most accessible mountain escapes.

What to do

- Harunire Terrace — a beautifully designed complex of restaurants and shops built around a grove of mature birch trees
- Shiraito Falls — a wide, shallow curtain of water over volcanic rock, ethereally quiet
- Old Karuizawa Ginza — the original resort street, mix of old boutiques and new cafes
- Cycling — rent bikes and ride the Cycling Road through the forest. The birch trees in September light are beautiful.
- Kutsukake no Yu — a classic onsen day spa if you want to relax without committing to a ryokan
- [Karuizawa tourism](#)
- [Harunire Terrace](#)

KYOTO & NARA

Kyoto — more kid-friendly than you'd expect

Kyoto Railway Museum

53 real trains including the original Shinkansen 0-series. A full-scale steam locomotive you can ride, and a spectacular roundhouse turntable. If your kids have even 1% train interest, this is a full day.

- [Kyoto Railway Museum](#)

Must-see temples & nature

- Fushimi Inari — the thousand torii gates. Go early morning to beat the crowds, the path continues up the mountain for as long as you want
- Arashiyama bamboo grove — ethereal, especially in morning light. Combine with a boat ride on the Oi River
- Kinkaku-ji (Golden Pavilion) — pure gold reflection on still water. A classic for good reason
- Nishiki Market — Kyoto's covered food market, great for snacking your way through
- [Kyoto official tourism](#)

Nara (day trip from Kyoto)

1,200 free-roaming deer that bow for crackers. The 5-year-old will lose their mind. Nara's Todai-ji temple holds Japan's largest bronze Buddha — scale that is genuinely awe-inspiring even for adults.

- [Nara tourism](#)

WAKAYAMA / PACIFIC COAST

Nanki-Shirahama

One of Japan's best beach destinations — white sand (unusual for Japan), dramatic ocean cliff walks, and a surprisingly world-class zoo. September is perfect: sea is still warm, crowds thinner than August.

Shirahama beaches & cliffs

- Shirahama Beach — white sand, turquoise water, the most photogenic beach in Honshu
- Sandanbeki Cliffs — dramatic 60m ocean cliffs, sea caves accessible by elevator
- Engetsu Island — a natural rock arch that frames sunsets perfectly
- [Shirahama tourism](#)

Adventure World

Japan's most famous panda breeding centre — home to more giant pandas than almost anywhere outside China. Safari drives, dolphin and killer whale shows, and close encounters that feel genuinely wild. Adults love this at least as much as kids do.

- [Adventure World](#)

Nagasaki

Japan's most international city — shaped by centuries of trade with China, the Netherlands, and Portugal when the rest of Japan was closed to the world. The result is an architecture, food culture, and atmosphere unlike anywhere else in Japan. Hilly, compact, and full of hidden staircases and viewpoints.

Hashima Island (Gunkanjima)

An abandoned coal mining island rising from the sea like a concrete battleship — once the most densely populated place on earth, now a haunting UNESCO World Heritage site. The 45-minute boat tour and guided ruins walk is one of Japan's most unforgettable experiences. Best for the 12-year-old.

- [Gunkanjima boat tour \(Yamasa Kaiun\)](#)

Nagasaki Chinatown (Shinchi)

One of Japan's three great Chinatowns — and arguably the most authentic. Nagasaki's Chinese community dates back 400 years, and the food here reflects that depth. Champon (a thick noodle soup with seafood and vegetables) was invented in Nagasaki and is the dish to eat. The lantern festival in February is world-famous, but the neighbourhood is worth visiting any time.

- Champon and sara udon at Ringer Hut or Kouzan-ro — the definitive Nagasaki meal
- Shinchi Chinatown — compact but atmospheric, best explored on foot
- [Nagasaki Chinatown info](#)

More Nagasaki highlights

- Glover Garden — a hillside park of 19th-century Western-style houses, with panoramic harbour views. The Madama Butterfly connection is here.
- Dejima — a reconstructed Dutch trading post from the closed-country era, a remarkable piece of living history
- Nagasaki Peace Park & Atomic Bomb Museum — sobering and important, particularly for the 12-year-old
- Inasayama Observatory — take the ropeway up for one of Japan's officially-certified three great night views
- Iojima Island — tiny volcanic island with natural hot springs flowing into the sea, almost no tourists, and spectacular sunsets
- [Nagasaki tourism](#)

Oita — Japan's onsen capital

Oita Prefecture produces more hot spring water than anywhere else on earth — more onsen, more volume, more variety than any other region in Japan. The onsen culture here is deep, unpretentious, and genuinely world-class.

Suginoi Hotel, Beppu

Beppu is the undisputed onsen capital of Japan — eight distinct hot spring zones (the 'eight hells'), volcanic steam rising from the streets, and a wonderfully retro resort town atmosphere. Suginoi Hotel sits on the hill above the city with sweeping bay views, and its onsen facilities are extraordinary: rooftop outdoor baths, indoor pools, a waterpark, and multiple spring types. It's a full resort in itself. Kids love the waterpark element; adults love the serious hot spring bathing.

- [Suginoi Hotel](#)

More Oita highlights

- Beppu Jigoku Meguri (Hell Tour) — seven dramatically different boiling hot spring pools, from blood-red to cobalt blue to one with crocodiles. Strange and brilliant.
 - Yufuin — Japan's most beautiful onsen village, ringed by mountains with a glassy lake at its centre. More refined than Beppu, excellent galleries and cafes.
 - Kunisaki Peninsula — one of Japan's most under-visited regions, with ancient stone Buddha carvings hidden in forests and a spiritual atmosphere unlike anywhere else
 - Usa Jingu — one of Japan's most important Shinto shrines, the origin of all Hachiman shrines nationwide
 - [Beppu tourism](#)
 - [Yufuin tourism](#)
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Insider kids list — places you must take them

These are the stops that will actually live in their memories:

- **teamLab Planets (Tokyo)** — Walk through digital art that responds to your body. The 5-year-old will be in pure awe. Book ahead — it sells out. teamlab.art
 - **Nara deer park** — 1,200 free-roaming deer that bow when you hold up a cracker. Free entry. narashikanko.or.jp
 - **Adventure World, Shirahama** — Japan's panda capital. Safari + shows + more giant pandas than almost anywhere on earth. aws-s.com/en
 - **Asahiyama Zoo, Hokkaido** — Polar bears swimming overhead through a glass tunnel. Penguins on parade. No other zoo in Japan compares. asahiynamazoo
 - **Kyoto Railway Museum** — 53 real trains. A steam locomotive you can ride. A spinning roundhouse. Japan's best train museum. kyotorailwaymuseum.jp/en
 - **Yokohama Cosmo World** — Right on the waterfront near Minato Mirai. Giant Ferris wheel, rides, candy floss. Easy from home for a quick evening. cosmoworld.jp
 - **OWakudani, Hakone** — Active volcanic steam vents and sulphur pools. Black eggs boiled in the springs (they're said to add 7 years to your life). Eerie and unforgettable. hakone.or.jp/en
 - **Fushimi Inari, Kyoto** — Ten thousand torii gates winding up a forested mountain. Go at 7am. It's a completely different experience from midday. Free entry.
 - **Any matsuri (festival)** — Early September still has summer festivals. Goldfish scooping, fireworks, yukata, food stalls. Pure Japan magic for kids.
 - **USJ (Osaka)** — Harry Potter world + Minions area + Nintendo World. The 12-year-old will never forget it. usj.co.jp/web/en
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Practical notes for September

- Weather: Early Sep = still hot (30-34°C). Late Sep = much more pleasant. Plan indoor activities in the first week.
- Typhoons: Peak mid-September — build flexibility into travel days, especially for Hokkaido or Kyushu legs
- Crowds: Lower than August almost everywhere — good timing
- Booking ahead: teamLab, USJ, and popular onsen ryokan should be booked weeks in advance
- JR Pass: Essential if covering Tokyo + Kyoto + Osaka + Hiroshima corridor. Buy before arriving in Japan.
- [JR Pass info](#)
- [Japan National Tourism \(official\)](#)
- [Google Maps Japan \(offline maps recommended\)](#)